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Creativity Connects: Generating Creative Ideas on Behalf of a Brand Increases Feelings of Connection

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Abstract

People are increasingly asked to generate creative ideas for brands in campaigns intended to generate new ideas. We draw on and extend a growing stream of research suggesting that being creative can foster social connection by showing that generating creative ideas for a brand can strengthen self-brand connection. In six pre-registered experiments (N = 1,635), participants worked on either a creative or less-creative product idea generation task. Creative (vs. less-creative) idea generators reported feeling more connected to the brand (Studies 1A and 1B), and these effects manifested in real product choices (Study 4). The underlying psychological mechanism, perceived self-disclosure, emerged via both mediation (Study 2) and moderation (Study 3). In a high-powered replication (Study 5), we addressed alternative explanations including effort, engagement, brand liking, and willingness to pay. We discuss the implications of our findings for the broader possibility that being creative can foster social connection—a source of psychological well-being.

Keywords

creativity, connection, self-disclosure, branding

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Brands are a ubiquitous and important feature of social life. The relationship humans form with brands affects the way individuals perceive their own identity (Aaker, 1997; Aggarwal & Law, 2005; Swaminathan et al., 2007). For example, a threat to a brand that one identifies with can be personally threatening (Lisjak et al., 2012), attitudes toward a brand can express one's self-concept and identity (Zunick et al., 2017; see also Morrison & Johnson, 2011), and people who own luxury brands are viewed as less warm (Cannon & Rucker, 2019). In fact, the relationship people form with brands can even provide feelings of security, just as human relationships do (Rindfleisch et al., 2009). As such, a deeper understanding of the factors that affect the human–brand relationship can shed light on human relationships in general.

Drawing on and extending recent research suggesting the possibility that being creative can foster social connection (Goncalo, Vincent, & Krause, 2015; Goncalo & Katz, 2020; Goncalo, Katz, Vincent, et al., 2021; Helzer & Kim, 2019; Kim, Goncalo, & Rodas, 2023; Kim, Zeppenfeld, & Cohen, 2013), we investigate the possibility that generating creative ideas on the brand's behalf can lead the ideator to feel more connected to the brand. Indeed, consumers are increasingly being asked to generate creative ideas for brands for practical reasons. For example, Lay's "Do Us a Flavor" is a crowdsourcing campaign that asks people for creative ideas for new potato chip flavors and awards $1 million USD to the best idea each year. In 2014 alone, people submitted 14.4 million ideas that led to an 8% increase in sales in the three months following the campaign (Franklin, 2018). Yet, the psychological implications of such endeavors might be easily overlooked.

By integrating research on the consequences of creativity with the literature on self-brand connection, we make three important theoretical contributions. First, we add creativity to the toolkit of interventions to increase feelings of connection, a pillar of social well-being. In so doing, we break from the typical focus on the antecedents of creativity (i.e., creativity as a dependent variable) to investigate the consequences of being creative (i.e., creativity as an independent variable), thereby answering growing calls for such research

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in social psychology and related fields (Berg et al., 2023; Godart et al., 2020; Goncalo, Vincent, & Krause, 2015; Goncalo & Katz, 2020; Harrison et al., 2022; Katz, 2020; Khessina et al., 2018; Kim, Goncalo, & Rodas, 2023; Krause et al., 2024; Lua et al., 2023; Sassenberg & Moskowitz, 2005; Wronska et al., 2018). Second, we contribute to the social psychology and communications literature by showing that the sharing of creative ideas can be a way to reveal oneself to a target (in this case a brand), thus paving the way for future research on novel ways to form different kinds of human relationships. Third, we contribute to the branding literature by introducing creative ideation as a tool for brands to increase self-brand connection, in addition to the practical goal of crowdsourcing campaigns to solicit ideas.

Disclosing the Self to a Brand Increases Self-Brand Connection

Creativity is defined as the generation of ideas, insights, or solutions that are both novel and useful in solving the problem at hand (Amabile, 1983, 1988; Sternberg & Lubart, 1999). Notions of novelty typically include newness, originality, uniqueness, and deviation from the status quo (Goncalo & Staw, 2006; Zhou & Shalley, 2008). Creative ideation (an important part of the creative process) refers to the process of generating original ideas in response to open-ended problems (Paulus & Brown, 2007). Most research on creative ideation has focused on how to boost the output of idea generators to ensure they advance a wide range of divergent ideas (e.g., Nijstad et al., 2010).

Yet, recent research suggests that engaging in the process of creative ideation can also have downstream psychological and behavioral consequences (Kim, Goncalo, & Rodas, 2023). One implication of this growing stream of research is that the creative process can be a vehicle for fostering social connection (Helzer & Kim, 2019; Goncalo, Katz, Vincent, et al., 2021). For instance, the expression of creative ideas can feel like an act of self-disclosure (Goncalo & Katz, 2020) and feelings of self-disclosure can facilitate the formation of social relationships (Willems et al., 2020).

Can the perception of self-disclosure foster a sense of connectedness between the idea generator and a brand? Recent research finds that idea generators feel psychologically attached to their own ideas (Lazar et al., 2022). This interesting finding hints at the possibility that idea generators could also feel attached to the target they are ideating for. Extensive marketing research has found that consumers form a relationship with their brands (Aaker et al., 2004; Fournier, 1998). This is possible because people perceive brands to have traits (Aaker, 1997), just as humans do. Perhaps more importantly, people associate brands with human-like characteristics (Keller, 1993).

Feelings of connectedness between an individual and a brand is often referred to as self-brand connection. Self-brand connection is defined as the extent to which individuals have incorporated brands into their self-concept (Escalas & Bettman, 2003; see also Sprott et al., 2009). When consumers feel connected to a brand, the brand is integrated into one's self-concept (Belk, 1988; Cheng et al., 2012), which establishes a sense of oneness with a brand (Park et al., 2010). Once self-brand connection is formed, then a brand's symbolic properties are used to communicate one's self-concept to others (Escalas & Bettman, 2009). As such, self-brand connection serves as an important part of individuals' relationship with brands (Tan et al., 2018).

In this research, we identify a novel way in which brands can foster a stronger self-brand connection, namely by asking people to generate creative ideas for them. We posit that such idea generation for a brand increases their perception of self-disclosure (Goncalo & Katz, 2020) toward the brand, which in turn increases feelings of connection with it. Self-disclosure includes the revelation of any personal information, including past experiences, future plans, feelings, attitudes, or beliefs (Willems et al., 2020), and such revelations foster emotional involvement, trust, and intimacy (Finkenauer & Buyukcan-Tetik, 2015)—known to contribute to the construction of relationships, as argued by social penetration theory (Altman & Taylor, 1973). More intimate disclosure has been shown to lead to higher liking of the discloser (Sprecher et al., 2013; Mikulincer & Nachshon, 1991; Worthy et al., 1969). For example, when influencers disclosed themselves more on social media, consumers felt more connected to them (Leite & Baptista, 2022; see also Huaman-Ramirez et al., 2022). Adding to the finding that brands disclosing themselves to the public increases the public's brand connection, we test whether an *individual's* self-disclosure toward a brand *through creative ideas* will increase his or her self-brand connection.

To summarize, we propose that generating creative ideas for a brand increases the ideator's feelings of self-disclosure toward the brand, which in turn increases feelings of connection with the brand. This effect is unique to creative ideation (vs. less-creative ideation). Therefore, we predict the following:

H1: Generating creative (vs. less-creative) ideas for a brand will increase individuals' feelings of connection with the brand.

H2: The effect of creative (vs. less-creative) ideation on individuals' increased feelings of connection with the brand will be mediated by feelings of self-disclosure toward the brand.

Ideas in a Vacuum? Self-Brand Connection When Ideas Are Not Shared

In theory, it's possible that individuals can generate creative ideas about brands without ever actually sharing them and generating ideas alone might be enough to foster a feeling of self-brand connection. However, this might not be plausible

given prior research on self-disclosure. For instance, Laurenceau et al. (1998) argue that feelings of connection might require more than just self-disclosure but also knowing a partner has received an act of self-disclosure (Reis & Patrick, 1996; Reis & Shaver, 1988). This logic suggests that strengthening self-brand connection through sharing creative ideas depends on the individual knowing that their ideas have been shared to and received by the brand. Thus, when the ideas have not been shared with the brand, communication—which requires interactions with a target (Dance, 1970; Mead, 1963)—becomes implausible and hence the formation of connection may be hindered. Accordingly, we consider an important possible boundary condition on the predicted effect—being able to share the generated ideas with the brand would facilitate greater feelings of self-disclosure and self-brand connection than simply generating creative ideas without sharing them. Formally, we hypothesize the following:

> *H3*: The effect of creative (vs. less-creative) ideation on individuals' increased feelings of connection with the brand will attenuate when the ideas are generated but not shared with the brand.

Overview of Studies

We test our hypotheses in a series of six pre-registered experiments conducted in both laboratory and real-world settings. In Study 1A, we demonstrate the main effect (Hypothesis 1), by comparing the effect of generating creative (vs. less-creative) product ideas on participants' feelings of connection with a brand. In Study 1B, we test how much connection consumers feel with a real brand, Lay's, after participating in their crowdsourcing campaign and compare it to another common way brands engage consumers: seeking (written) feedback. In Study 2, we test the underlying process mechanism (Hypothesis 2) by showing that idea generators' self-brand connection increases due to increased feelings of self-disclosure toward a brand. In Study 3, we shed light on the underlying process mechanism through a moderation approach (Hypothesis 3). In Study 4, we test Hypothesis 1 by measuring self-brand connection with a behavioral choice measure. In Study 5, we address a range of possible alternative explanations such as task equivalence, effort, engagement, brand liking, and willingness to pay. For each experiment, all measures, manipulations, and exclusions in the experiment are disclosed. All analyses were conducted after data collection was complete. Our materials and data are viewable online as supplemental material at https://osf.io/3bpvr/.

Study 1A

In Study 1A, we test Hypothesis 1 that engaging in creative (vs. less-creative) product development strengthens feelings of connection with the brand a participant generates ideas for. To test this idea, participants were told that the task is about product development and asked to generate ideas for creative (vs. less-creative) types of candle scents. We subsequently measured the idea generator's self-brand connection with a (fictitious) candle brand after working on the task. We predicted that those in the creative task (i.e., new product development) condition would feel a stronger self-brand connection, as compared to those in the less-creative task (i.e., conventional product development) condition. We control for mood to rule it out as the driver of the effect. This study was pre-registered (https://aspredicted.org/CXJ_RKC).

Pretest of Task Equivalence

We conducted a pre-test (data are available on OSF) to verify that the task itself does not introduce confounds: likability of the target brand, expected effort to be exerted on the task, helpfulness, enjoyability, and meaningfulness of task (pre-registered at: https://aspredicted.org/C3G_LKZ). We recruited 100 participants from Prolific Academic (55% women, Age_{mean} = 36.68, Age_{SD} = 12.67) for $0.40 USD per participant. Five participants did not pass a one-item attention check.

Pretest Procedure. After reading the task instructions, but before actually working on the task, participants were asked the following questions outlined below. Participants responded to a four-item scale (five-point Likert-type response; e.g., anchored at 1: bad, 5: good) indicating the *likability* of the brand Melody Candle. Then participants were asked the following questions regarding the task: "How much *effort* do you think you would exert when working on the task?" "How *helpful* do you think you would be to the brand by working on the task?" "How *enjoyable* do you think the task will be?" "How *meaningful* do you think the task will be?" in a one-item scale each (five-point Likert-type response).

Pre-Test Results. A one-way ANOVA revealed that there were no differences in any of the dependent variables measured. Specifically, the two conditions did not differ in terms of how much they liked the target brand (M_{Creative} = 3.59 and $M_{\text{Less-creative}}$ = 3.57, p = .89), expected effort to be exerted (M_{Creative} = 3.62 and $M_{\text{Less-creative}}$ = 3.50, p = .55), perceived helpfulness (M_{Creative} = 3.60 and $M_{\text{Less-creative}}$ = 3.48, p = .57), perceived enjoyability (M_{Creative} = 3.27 and $M_{\text{Less-creative}}$ = 3.30, p = .88), and meaningfulness (M_{Creative} = 3.16 and $M_{\text{Less-creative}}$ = 2.84, p = .15). The likability measure was an average of the four items (α = .96), and the results did not differ when analyzing each item separately.

Method

Participants. Based on power analysis using G*Power, we recruited 300 participants from Prolific Academic (45%

women, Age_{mean} = 39.65, Age_{SD} = 13.58) for $0.90 USD per participant. The analysis had 80% power to detect an effect size of f = .162. The sample size and exclusion criteria were pre-registered. Excluding participants did not affect the results. Before any analysis was conducted, 20 participants were excluded according to the pre-registered criteria, leaving a final n = 280. Specifically, 2 began the survey but did not finish, 3 did not pass an attention check that asked to choose a specific number from a five-point Likert-type scale, and 15 were timed out for working on the task for more than 7 min—which could be a sign of working on multiple tasks. Of those, 136 were in the creative task condition and 144 were in the less-creative task condition. Based on a sensitivity power analysis with this sample, a statistical power of 80%, and $p < .05$, the minimum effect that can be found is f = .168.

Procedure. Participants were randomly assigned to one of two conditions of a single-factor (task: creative, less-creative), between-subjects design. Those randomly assigned to the creative (vs. less-creative) task condition were asked to generate *novel* (vs. *generic*) candle scent ideas for a fictitious brand "Melody Candle," following procedures used in previous research (Goncalo & Katz, 2020). To minimize the differences between the creative and less-creative tasks, we only changed the description of what type of candle scent ideas the participants will generate. Participants read the following prompt and the wording in parentheses varied by condition (creative vs. less-creative):

> A candle company named "Melody Candle" is planning to launch a line of candles. This next section is a task about product development to help them. We are looking for some ideas for (new/typical) types of scented candles that are (creative and novel/generic and conventional). Please write as many (creative/generic) ideas as possible for (new/word omitted) candle scents. Please work on this task for 4 minutes.

Following the ideation task, the participants responded to the following items: self-brand connection and mood.

Measures

Self-Brand Connection. Upon completing the creative (vs. less-creative) task, participants responded to a seven-item scale (five-point Likert-type response) indicating their self-brand connection (Escalas, 2004) with Melody Candle, which is the brand they generated ideas for. The seven items were, "The brand Melody Candle reflects who I am," "I can identify with the brand Melody Candle," "I feel a personal connection to the brand Melody Candle," "I can use the brand Melody Candle to communicate who I am to other people," "I think the brand Melody Candle could help me become the type of person I want to be," "I consider the brand Melody Candle to be 'me' (it reflects who I consider myself to be or the way that I want to present myself to others)," and "The brand Melody Candle suits me well." After checking for reliability (α = .93), self-brand connection items were averaged to constitute the main dependent variable.

Positive and Negative Affect. PANAS (Positive and Negative Affect Schedule) scale (Watson et al., 1988) was used to measure participants' mood, so that we can rule it out as a potential confound. Mood items were reliable (positive, α = .78; negative, α = .86) and thus averaged.

Creativity Manipulation Check. Two independent coders scored the creativity of the participants' candle scent ideas, following Goncalo and Katz (2020). Specifically, two trained coders who were blind to the experimental condition and predictions of the study coded each idea for creativity, which was defined as "the extent to which the idea does not resemble the typical candle scent." Each coder was given a scale of 1 to 5, with the following scale anchors: 1 = *Scent that is extremely common in the set of ideas and in real life, which are the basic and default scents always expected to be available*; 3 = *Scent that may be seen on occasion or could imagine existing*; 5 = *Scent that really would not have been expected before*. The coders did not rate ideas that were unrelated to scents (e.g., reasonably priced, or pleasing colors). Ideas such as "the Lord's booty hole," "new tennis ball," "zombie fart," and "burnt tires" were anchors for creative ideas, whereas ideas such as "vanilla," "apple orchard," "jasmine," and "lavender" were anchors for generic ideas. The inter-rater correlation was significant (ICC = 0.88, $p < .001$) so the scores of the two coders were averaged together.

Results

Manipulation Check. Participants in the creative condition generated ideas that are more creative ($M_{Creative}$ = 2.55, SD = .58) than those who were in the generic condition ($M_{Less\text{-}creative}$ = 1.83, SD = .41, $F[1, 273]$ = 142.85, $p < .001$, $\eta p2$ = .344, d = 1.45, 95% CI [0.60, 0.84]), indicating that the task indeed led to the generation of creative (vs. generic) ideas.

Main Analyses. Participants in the creative task condition ($M_{Creative}$ = 2.82, SD = .89) reported feeling a significantly stronger self-brand connection than those who were in the less-creative condition ($M_{Less\text{-}creative}$ = 2.53, SD = .82, $F[1, 278]$ = 7.84, p = .005, $\eta p2$ = .027, d = .33, 95% CI [0.08, 0.49]), supporting hypothesis 1. The interpretation of the results did not change when controlling for mood ($F[1, 276]$ = 7.502, p = .026, $\eta p2$ = .041). Controlling for mood did not change the interpretation of the results in the following studies and thus we report the results controlling for mood in the Web Appendix B in subsequent studies.

The result held even when controlling for engagement and mood. Specifically, we did not hypothesize any difference

between conditions on the number of ideas generated, but found that less-creative task condition participants ($M_{\text{Less-creative}}$ = 15.17, SD = 7.29) generated a significantly higher number of ideas compared to creative task condition participants (M_{Creative} = 12.33, SD = 6.39, $F[1, 278] = 11.94$, $p < .001$, $\eta p^2 = .041$). Our results remained significant when controlling for the number of ideas generated in addition to mood ($F[1, 275] = 7.839$, $p = .028$, $\eta p^2 = .042$), so we did not consider it further.

Discussion

The results supported hypothesis 1. Participants who worked on the creative (vs. less-creative) ideation task reported feeling a stronger connection with the brand they generated ideas for (i.e., Melody Candle).

Study 1B

In this experiment, we investigate whether involving consumers by asking for creative ideas leads to stronger brand connections compared to involving them in a less-creative way, such as by asking for feedback (hypothesis 1). This study was pre-registered (https://aspredicted.org/LFR_LWV).

Method

Participants. Based on power analysis using G*Power, 200 participants (68% women, Age_{mean} = 20.75, Age_{SD} = 2.19) from a large public university in the United States were recruited for course credit. The analysis had 80% power to detect an effect size of $f = .199$. The sample size and exclusion criteria were pre-registered. Before any analysis was conducted, 11 participants were excluded according to the pre-registered criteria, leaving a final $n = 189$. Specifically, 11 did not pass a simple attention check. Of those, 94 were in the creative task condition and 95 were in the less-creative task condition. Based on a sensitivity power analysis with this sample, a statistical power of 80%, and $p < .05$, the minimum effect that can be found is $f = .205$.

Procedure. Participants were randomly assigned to one of two conditions of a single-factor (task: crowdsourcing, feedback), between-subjects design. After signing the consent form, participants completed a given task and then worked on a survey described below. Those randomly assigned to the crowdsourcing task condition were asked to generate novel ideas of new potato chip flavor for a real existing brand Lay's, following the Lay's crowdsourcing campaign "Do Us a Flavor." Participants read the following prompt:

> We would love to hear from you! We are looking to launch a new flavor of potato chips and would like your help. We are looking for ideas for new potato chips flavors that are creative and novel. Please write as many creative ideas as possible for new potato chips flavors for Lay's.

In the feedback condition, participants read the following prompt, which was directly copied from Lay's "contact us" page (see Web Appendix A) on their website:

> We would love to hear from you! Please give Lay's feedback.

The participants were free to quit working on the task whenever they wished. Following the main task, the participants responded to the items described below.

Measures

Self-Brand Connection. We used identical items to Study 1A but changed the brand name to Lay's. These items were averaged after checking for reliability ($\alpha = .92$).

Positive and Negative Affect. We used identical items to Study 1A. These items were averaged after checking for reliability (positive, $\alpha = .80$; negative, $\alpha = .83$).

Familiarity With Lay's. To ensure participants across the two conditions did not differ in their familiarity with the brand Lay's, we asked "How familiar are you with the brand Lay's?" on a five-point Likert type scale (1: not familiar at all, 5: very familiar).

Lay's Purchase Frequency. To ensure participants across the two conditions did not differ in their purchase frequency of Lay's products, we asked "How frequently do you purchase Lay's products?" on a five-point Likert-type scale (1: not often at all, 5: very often). Familiarity and purchase frequency were measured at the very beginning of the study.

Results

Main Analyses. Participants in the crowdsourcing condition (M_{Creative} = 2.46, SD = .88) reported feeling significantly stronger self-brand connection ($F[1, 187] = 5.65$, $p = .018$, $\eta p2 = .029$, $d = .35$, 95% CI [0.05, 0.53]) than those who were in the feedback condition ($M_{\text{Less-creative}}$ = 2.17, SD = .80). Controlling for mood did not affect the interpretation of the results ($F[1, 187] = 5.36$, $p = .022$, $\eta p2 = .033$).

We followed the pre-registration and conducted a post-hoc analysis which revealed that participants who worked on the crowdsourcing task (M_{Creative} = 96.02 seconds, SD = 42.43) worked longer ($F[1, 187] = 28.72$, $p < .001$, $\eta p2 = .133$, 95% CI [18.69, 40.47]) than those who worked on the feedback task ($M_{\text{Less-creative}}$ = 66.43 s, SD = 32.90). Therefore, we controlled for time engaged on the task after log-transforming it as it was skewed (Kurtosis = 1.37). The results remained significant even after controlling for time ($F[1, 187] = 4.14$, $p = .043$, $\eta p2 = .030$). Post-hoc analyses also

showed that the two conditions did not differ in familiarity with the brand Lay's ($F[1, 187] = .46$, $p = .499$, $\eta p2 = .002$, 95% CI [−0.12, 0.24]) or purchase frequency of Lay's products ($F[1, 187] = 2.80$, $p = .096$, $\eta p2 = .015$, 95% CI [−0.04, 0.60]).

Discussion

This study compared the effect of involving participants in two common marketing campaigns on their self-brand connection. The results showed that generating creative ideas in a crowdsourcing campaign yields stronger feelings of self-brand connection compared to merely giving feedback[1] to a brand, supporting hypothesis 1 and replicating the results of the previous study.

Study 2

In hypothesis 2, we predicted that creative ideation strengthens the idea generator's self-brand connection because sharing creative ideas increases feelings of self-disclosure toward a brand. In this study, we test this underlying mechanism that leads creative idea generators to feel connected to a brand by measuring feelings of self-disclosure directly. This study was pre-registered (https://aspredicted.org/H3P_8ZB).

Method

Participants. Based on power analysis using G*Power (Faul et al., 2007), 249 participants (57.4% women, $Age_{mean} = 20.81$, $Age_{SD} = 3.17$) from a large public university in the United States were recruited for course credit. The analysis had 80% power to detect an effect size of $f = .178$. The sample size and exclusion criteria (same criteria as study 1B) were pre-registered. Before any analysis was conducted, 51 participants were excluded according to the pre-registered criteria, leaving a final $n = 198$. Specifically, 12 began the survey but did not finish, 23 did not pass a simple attention check, and 20 were timed out. Of those, 102 were in the creative task condition and 96 were in the less-creative task condition. Based on a sensitivity power analysis with this sample, a statistical power of 80%, and $p < .05$, the minimum effect that can be found is $f = .200$.

Procedure. Similar to Study 1A, participants generated ideas then completed a survey described below. Those randomly assigned to the creative (vs. less-creative) task condition were asked to generate *novel* (vs. *generic*) ideas of new potato chip flavor for a real existing brand "Ten Acre" for 7 min. We chose 7 min following the procedures used in previous research (e.g. Duguid & Goncalo, 2015, Study 4). We pre-tested to find out that this British potato chip brand was unfamiliar to U.S. residents ($M = 1.05$ on a five-point Likert-type scale anchored at 1: not familiar at all, 5: very familiar), to reduce the effect of prior brand liking or knowledge.

Measures

Self-Brand Connection. We used identical items to the previous studies and simply changed the brand name to "Ten Acre." After checking for reliability ($\alpha = .90$), self-brand connection items were averaged to constitute the main dependent variable.

Perception of Self-Disclosure. After indicating self-brand connection, participants also responded to a four-item scale (five-point Likert-type response) indicating the extent to which one felt s/he disclosed the self to a brand (Goncalo & Katz, 2020). The items are the following: "The ideas I generated reveal something about my personality to the brand Ten Acre," "The ideas I generated demonstrate something about me to the brand Ten Acre," "The ideas I generated indicate some of what I am like as a person to the brand Ten Acre," and "The ideas I generated do not reveal anything about me to the brand Ten Acre" (reverse scored). After checking for reliability ($\alpha = .80$), perception of self-disclosure items was averaged to constitute the mediating variable.

Positive and Negative Affect. We used identical items to Study 1A. Mood items were reliable (positive, $\alpha = .71$; negative, $\alpha = .81$) and thus averaged.

Creativity Manipulation Check. Two independent coders scored the creativity of the participants' candle scent ideas, just as in study 1A. Two independent coders rated the creativity of ideas, as in Study 1A. The inter-rater correlation was significant (ICC = 0.82, $p < 0.001$), so the scores of the two coders were averaged together.

Results

Manipulation Check. Confirming the efficacy of our manipulation, participants in the creative condition generated ideas that are more creative ($M_{Creative} = 2.41$, $SD = .51$) than those who were in the control condition ($M_{Less\text{-}creative} = 1.39$, $SD = .40$, $F[1, 194] = 237.28$, $p < .001$, $\eta p2 = .550$, $d = 2.21$, 95% CI [0.88, 1.14]), indicating that the task indeed led to the generation of creative (vs. generic) ideas.

Main Analyses. Participants in the creative task condition ($M_{Creative} = 2.43$, $SD = .77$) reported feeling significantly stronger self-brand connection than those who were in the less-creative condition ($M_{Less\text{-}creative} = 2.17$, $SD = .78$, $F[1, 196] = 5.58$, $p = .019$, $\eta p2 = .028$, 95% CI [0.04, 0.48]), replicating prior study results.

Participants in the creative task condition ($M_{Creative} = 3.15$, $SD = .88$) reported feeling significantly stronger feelings of self-disclosure than those who were in the less-creative condition ($M_{Less\text{-}creative} = 2.86$, $SD = .90$, $F[1, 196] = 4.99$, $p = .027$, $\eta p2 = .025$, 95% CI [0.03, 0.53]).

Table 1. Correlations Table (Study 2).

Measure	1. Novelty	2. Self-dis	3. SBC	4. Idea No	5. Pos	6. Neg
1.Idea novelty (score rated by 2 coders)	1	.240**	.185**	.306***	.053	−.014
2.Self-disclosure perception		1	.527***	.116	.025	−.081
3.Self-brand connection			1	.061	.068	−.010
4.Number of ideas generated				1	.082	.065
5.Positive affect					1	−.064
6.Negative affect						1

*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

Mediation Analysis. The relationship between creative (vs. less-creative) ideation task and self-brand connection was (fully) mediated by feelings of self-disclosure (see Figure 1). A bootstrap analysis (5,000 samples) of the mediation model (Hayes, 2012, Model 4) was run using PROCESS macro. Creative engagement did not increase self-brand connection (direct effect: unstandardized $B = .13$, $SE = .10$, 95% CI [−0.06, 0.32]) and feelings of self-disclosure increased feelings of self-brand connection (direct effect: unstandardized $B = .45$, $SE = .05$, 95% CI [0.34, 0.55]). Feelings of self-disclosure significantly mediated the effect of creative engagement on self-brand connection (indirect effect: unstandardized $B = .13$, $SE = .06$, 95% CI [0.02, 0.25]), supporting hypothesis 2.[2,3]

Discussion

The results of Studies 1A, 1B, and 2 demonstrate the robustness and replicability of the effect of generating creative ideas for a brand on strengthening the idea generator's self-brand connection. The results of Study 2 also shed light on the underlying psychological mechanism: Perception of self-disclosure (fully) mediated the effect of engaging in creative ideation on increasing self-brand connection, supporting Hypothesis 2 (Figure 1). Creative ideation allowed participants to disclose themselves toward a brand for which they generated ideas. This, in turn, increased the participants' self-brand connection.

Factor analysis results in the Web Appendix C reveal that self-brand connection and self-disclosure variables are empirically distinct. The causal ordering of a mediation hypothesis implies a conceptual time ordering (causal-temporal constraints on mediation models; Tate, 2015). Conceptually, we argue that participants' perception of the creative task (e.g., self-disclosure) leads to self-brand connection. We do not think that the reverse is plausible—that feelings of connection changed participants' perception of the task. But given the correlational nature of the mediation analysis, we cannot rule out this possibility (Table 1).

Feelings of connection was driven by feelings of self-disclosure that may require knowing that a partner has received an act of self-disclosure. Accordingly, we hypothesized in hypothesis 3 that if the ideas are not shared with the brand, then creative engagement may not increase self-brand connection because the idea generator would not be able to reveal one's self toward the brand. Thus, in the following study, we introduce a moderator: sharing (vs. not sharing) ideas. We expected that being told their ideas will not be shared with the brand will mute the effect of creative engagement on self-brand connection.

Study 3

In this study, we test the boundary condition of the effect we found in the previous studies (hypothesis 3), which will help us understand the process mechanism behind the main effect through the "moderation-of-process approach" (Fiedler et al., 2011; Spencer et al., 2005). Specifically, we test whether creative (vs. less-creative) ideation would *not* increase self-brand connection when ideas are not shared with the brand because it will hinder feelings of self-disclosure. To test this, we manipulate whether ideas will be shared with the brand or not by telling the participants that their ideas will (vs. will not) be shared or be read by the focal brand. Accordingly, the study employed a 2 (Task: Creative vs. Less-Creative) × 2 (Idea Shared: Yes, No) between-subjects design. This study was pre-registered (https://aspredicted.org/931_9YV).

Method

Participants. Based on power analysis using G*Power, we recruited 324 participants from Prolific Academic (54.9% women, $Age_{mean} = 36.91$, $Age_{SD} = 13.82$) for $0.95 USD per participant. The analysis had 80% power to detect an effect size of $f = .185$. The sample size and exclusion criteria were pre-registered. Before any analysis was conducted, 17 participants were excluded according to the pre-registered criteria (identical to study 1B), leaving a final $n = 307$. Specifically, 2 did not pass a simple attention check and 15 were timed out. Of those remaining, 153 were in the creative task condition and 154 were in the less-creative task condition. Based on a sensitivity power analysis with this sample, a statistical power of 80%, and $p < .05$, the minimum effect that can be found is $f = .190$.

Procedure. The procedure is similar to Study 1A with one key difference: Before participants generated either creative (vs. less-creative) ideas, we manipulated whether those ideas

would (vs. would not) be shared with the company, Melody Candle. Specifically, participants in the "sharing" (vs. "no sharing") condition read the following:

> Please note that your ideas will (vs. will not) be shared with the brand Melody Candle and will (vs. will not) be read by everyone (vs. anyone) at Melody Candle.

After participants engaged in the creative task, we measured the dependent variable as in Study 1A.

Measures

Self-Brand Connection. We used identical items to Study 1A. After checking for reliability ($\alpha = .94$), items were averaged to constitute the main dependent variable.

Positive and Negative Affect. We used identical items to the previous studies. Mood items were reliable (positive, $\alpha = .83$; negative, $\alpha = .84$) and thus averaged.

Creativity Manipulation Check. Two independent coders rated the creativity of ideas, as in Study 1A. The inter-rater correlation was significant (ICC = .94, $p < .001$) so the scores of the two coders were averaged together.

Results

Manipulation Check. As intended, participants in the creative condition generated ideas that are more creative ($M_{\text{Creative}} = 2.75$, $SD = .49$) than those who were in the control condition ($M_{\text{Less-creative}} = 1.93$, $SD = .34$, $F[1, 302] = 292.15$, $p < .001$, $\eta p2 = .492$, $d = 1.97$, 95% CI [0.73, 0.92]), indicating that the task indeed led to the generation of creative (vs. generic) ideas.[4]

Main Analysis. There was no main effect of task (creative vs. less-creative) on self-brand connection ($F[1, 305] = 1.75$, $p = .187$, $\eta p2 = .006$, $d = .16$, 95% CI [−0.07, 0.36]). There was no main effect of idea sharing condition (yes vs. no) on self-brand connection ($F[1, 305] = .993$, $p = .320$, $\eta p2 = .003$, $d = .11$, 95% CI [−0.11, 0.32]). We found a moderating effect of "idea sharing condition" on the effect of creative ideation on self-brand connection. There was a significant interaction between the creativity and idea sharing conditions ($F[3, 303] = 3.91$, $p = 0.049$, 95% CI [0.00, 0.41]) when controlling for mood. The interaction became marginal when not controlling for mood ($F[3, 303] = 2.90$, $p = .090$, 95% CI [−0.03, 0.40]).

Planned contrast analysis using ANOVA, which was preregistered as the main analysis, revealed that in the "idea shared" condition, participants in the creative task condition ($M_{\text{Creative}} = 2.76$, $SD = .92$) reported feeling a stronger self-brand connection ($F[1, 147] = 4.50$, $p = .036$, $\eta p2 = .030$, $d = .35$, 95% CI [0.02, 0.64]) than those who were in the less-creative task condition ($M_{\text{Less-creative}} = 2.42$, $SD = 1.00$).

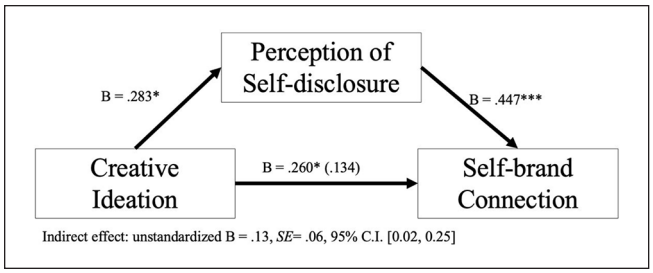

Figure 1. Mediating effect of perception of self-disclosure on the effect of creative (vs. less-creative) task on self-brand connection (Study 2).
*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

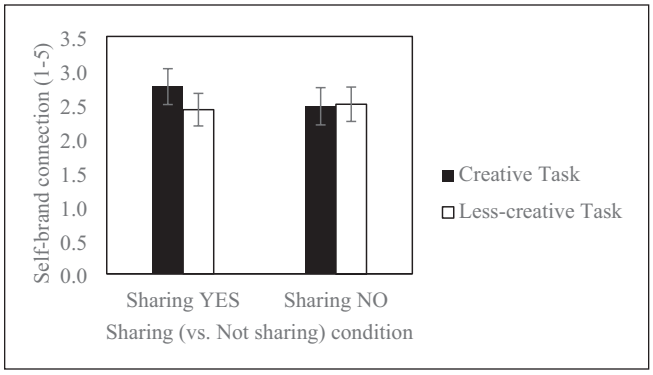

Figure 2. The effect of creative (vs. less-creative) task on self-brand connection by sharing condition (Study 3). Error bars denote 95% CI.

However, in the "idea not shared" condition, participants in the creative task condition ($M_{\text{Creative}} = 2.47$, $SD = .97$) did not report feeling different in self-brand connection ($F[1, 156] = .06$, $p = .808$, $\eta p2 = .000$, $d = .00$, 95% CI [−0.33, 0.26]) than those who were in the less-creative task condition ($M_{\text{Less-creative}} = 2.50$, $SD = .92$) (see Figure 2).

Discussion

Study 3 results supported hypothesis 3 by showing that creative ideation increases self-brand connection only when the generated ideas are shared with the focal brand so that consumers can feel a sense of self-disclosure. This study offered further insight into the process mechanism behind the main effect through the "moderation-of-process approach" (Fiedler et al., 2011; Spencer et al., 2005).

It is possible to question whether the "not sharing" task condition could have made the task feel less important to the participants—thereby reducing self-brand connection. We investigated this possibility by looking at the control conditions within the 'sharing' and 'not sharing' conditions (see Figure 2). Participants in the less-creative task condition showed similar self-brand connection whether their ideas were shared or not shared, ruling out the possibility

that the "not sharing" condition simply made the task less important.

Study 4

In this study, we increased the external validity of our findings by testing hypothesis 1 in an interesting context with higher mundane realism, where participants can engage with brands in a more natural and realistic environment. We also extended previous studies by testing the possibility that increased self-brand connection can be reflected in consumers' real behavioral choices because possessions are linked to the self and can even serve as the basis of one's self-worth (Ferraro et al., 2011). Specifically, at the end of the study, participants were given a choice between a water bottle that displayed either the logo of the brand they ideated for versus a control brand's logo. Accordingly, the behavioral choice measure of this study provided more direct evidence of consumer–brand relationship (Morwitz et al., 2007) compared to attitudinal measures. We expected participants who generated creative (vs. generic) ideas for a brand to choose to receive a gift (i.e., water bottle) with the focal brand's logo (vs. an unfamiliar fictitious brand's logo) displayed. We selected a water bottle as the choice outcome because highly visible goods are well suited for conveying consumers' self-concepts (Escalas & Bettman, 2003, 2005) and water bottles are visible to others daily. This study was pre-registered (https://aspredicted.org/F4K_GMT).

Method

Participants. Based on power analysis using G*Power, we recruited 302 participants (57% women, $Age_{mean} = 21.81$, $Age_{SD} = 2.95$) from the lobby of a business school building located in a large public university in the United States. The analysis had 80% power to detect an effect size of $f = .162$. Participants were provided with a water bottle of their *choice* in appreciation of participation after completing the study and this choice constituted the key dependent variable. The sample size and exclusion criteria were pre-registered. Before any analysis was conducted, 42 participants were excluded according to the pre-registered criteria, leaving a final $n = 260$. Specifically, 41 did not pass a simple attention check, 1 did not generate any idea, and 1 left the study unfinished. Of those remaining, 133 were in the creative task condition and 127 were in the less-creative task condition. Based on a sensitivity power analysis with this sample, a statistical power of 80%, and $p < .05$, the minimum effect that can be found is $f = .174$.

Procedure. Participants were randomly assigned to one of two conditions of a single-factor (task: creative, less-creative), between-subjects design. After signing a consent form, the participants completed a given task on a table in the lobby of a business school. On the table, candles with Melody Candle logo (see Web Appendix A) were placed so that participants can interact with it whenever they wanted. Those randomly assigned to the treatment (vs. control) task condition were asked to generate creative (vs. less-creative) candle scent ideas for a fictitious brand "Melody Candle," following procedures used in Study 1A. Afterward, the participants responded to the following items listed below.

Measures

Behavioral Measure of Self-Brand Connection. Participants were offered a gift for them to keep at the end of the study. They had a choice between a *water bottle* with Melody Candle (i.e., focal brand) logo or Harmony Candle (i.e., unfamiliar fictitious brand) logo. We pre-tested these two fictitious brand names and logos to make sure their likability is similar. This choice constituted the main dependent variable. Additional variables measured in the study are reported in Web Appendix C.

Positive and Negative Affect. Similar to the previous studies, items were averaged after checking for reliability (positive, $\alpha = .75$; negative, $\alpha = .77$).

Creativity Manipulation Check. Two independent coders rated the creativity of ideas, as in Study 1A. The inter-rater correlation was significant (ICC = 0.93, $p < .001$) so the scores of the two coders were averaged together.

Results

Manipulation Check. Participants in the creative condition generated ideas that are more creative ($M_{Creative} = 2.60$, $SD = .55$) than those who were in the control condition ($M_{Less\text{-}creative} = 2.03$, $SD = 0.36$, $F[1, 248] = 89.66$, $p < .001$, $\eta p2 = .266$, $d = 1.20$, 95% CI [0.44, 0.68]), indicating that the task indeed led to the generation of creative (vs. generic) ideas.

Main Analysis. Out of two possible water bottle choices that differed in displayed brand logo (see Web Appendix A), 67% (vs. 54%) of the participants in the creative (vs. less-creative) task condition chose to receive a water bottle with "Melody Candle" logo, instead of an unfamiliar brand "Harmony Candle" logo, resulting in a significant difference in choice ($X^2[1, 258] = 4.35$, $p = .037$).

Discussion

The results provided further evidence that generating creative ideas for a brand strengthens feelings of connection with the brand and that this materializes in behavioral choices idea generators make. Specifically, participants chose to keep a water bottle that displayed the name of the brand they ideated for—but this was the case only for those who generated creative (vs. less-creative) ideas for

the brands. We examined the causal relationship by testing the ecological validity in a more natural setting. Participants were able to physically interact with the brand by touching and interacting with candles from the brand and were also given the option to take pictures of the products. Through this study, we tried to overcome the limitation of only using self-reported attitudinal measures in a lab setting. Our dependent measure of self-brand connection—the selection of a water bottle, afforded the opportunity to test the formation of self-brand connection as it is a highly visible good used on a daily basis in public (Park et al., 2010).

Study 5

In this experiment, we try to increase the statistical validity of our findings by increasing the sample size. We also try to rule out an alternative explanation for our effect that generating typical, generic, and conventional ideas in the control condition (i.e., "less-creative ideation") from the previous studies may not have been a completely neutral stimulus if the word "generic" might have a somewhat negative connotation. We therefore modified the control condition to have participants simply describe the brand instead of generating less-creative (generic) ideas. This approach keeps the brand salient in both conditions while removing any perceived negativity in the control condition. Lastly, we collected post-task measures (effort, engagement, positive feelings about the task, liking of the brand/task, positive feelings toward the brand, and willingness to pay) to test whether these factors might explain the effect. This study was pre-registered (https://aspredicted.org/gh82-pkk9.pdf).

Method

Participants. In order to achieve 95% power to detect an effect size of $d = .36$ (or $f = .255$), our goal was to have more than 202 observations per condition. Because each wave of data collection was capped at 275 participants, we combined two waves and excluded duplicates. A total of 520 participants (36% women, $\text{Age}_{\text{mean}} = 37.97$, $\text{Age}_{SD} = 8.28$) from a large public university in the United States were recruited for course credit. The sample size and exclusion criteria were pre-registered. Before any analysis was conducted, 119 participants were excluded[5] according to the pre-registered criteria, leaving a final $n = 401$. Specifically, 57 did not pass a simple attention check, 38 wrote very low-effort responses or did not write anything, 41 were excluded since they have taken the study twice, and 4 were timed out for working on the task for more than 10 min. Of those, 209 were in the creative task condition and 192 were in the "describe the brand" task condition. Based on a sensitivity power analysis with this sample, a statistical power of 95%, and $p < .05$, the minimum effect that can be found is $f = .18$.

Procedure. Following the method of Study 1A, participants generated ideas then completed a survey described below. All participants first read the following prompt:

> Melody Candle currently carries scents such as vanilla, lavender, and lilac. It is headquartered in Iowa. It is a small company. Please work on a task about Melody Candle on the following page.

Those randomly assigned to the creative (vs. describe Melody Brand) task condition were asked to generate novel ideas for the brand Melody Candle (vs. describe the brand Melody Candle). The "creative task" condition had the same task instructions as in Study 1A.[6] In the "describe Melody Candle" condition, participants read the following prompt:

> Please think back to the information you read about the brand Melody Candle. Then, please write as many descriptions about the brand as possible.

The participants were free to quit working on the task whenever they wished. Following the main task, the participants responded to the items described below.

Measures

Self-Brand Connection. We used identical items to Study 1A but changed the brand name to Lay's. These items were averaged after checking for reliability ($\alpha = .93$).

Positive and Negative Affect. We used identical items to Study 1A. These items were averaged after checking for reliability (positive, $\alpha = .75$; negative, $\alpha = .81$).

Post-Test Task Equivalence Measures. To check whether the two different tasks did not introduce confounds that may provide room for alternative explanations, we measured the following variables: effort exerted in the task, task engagement, positive feelings about the task, liking of the brand/task, positive feelings toward the brand, and willingness to pay for the candles.

Results

Main Analyses. Participants in the creative task condition ($M_{\text{Creative}} = 2.66$, $SD = .81$) reported feeling a significantly stronger self-brand connection than those who were in the "describe the brand" condition ($M_{\text{Brand-description}} = 2.47$, $SD = .88$, $F[1, 399] = 4.89$, $p = .024$, $\eta p2 = .013$, $d = .23$, 95% CI [0.03, 0.36]). We followed the pre-registration and conducted post hoc analyses. The analyses revealed that there were no differences in the interpretation of the results when the post-test variables were added as covariates, regardless of

whether we controlled for each post-test variable separately or all together. Please see Web Appendix B for details.

Discussion

Our effect was again replicated using an alternative and more neutrally worded control condition. Moreover, measuring post-task variables allowed us to rule out differences in effort, engagement, positive affect, brand liking, or willingness to pay as explanations for why generating creative ideas increases self-brand connection. Finally, our larger sample size in this study bolsters confidence in the replicability of these effects.

General Discussion

Our research heeds recent calls for research on the psychological consequences of creativity by showing that sharing creative ideas can strengthen self-brand connection via perceived self-disclosure, thus extending recent research suggesting that creativity can foster social connection. Our findings have theoretical implications for creativity, the self, and the formation of social relationships.

Summary of Findings

Across six experiments we showed that when participants generate creative ideas for brands, they feel a stronger self-brand connection compared to (1) generating less-creative ideas (Study 1A), (2) simply providing feedback to the brand (Study 1B), or (3) simply describing the brand (Study 5). Such feelings led to corresponding behavioral choices in a more externally valid setting (Study 4). This was because generating creative ideas made participants feel like they disclosed a unique part of one's self to the brand (Studies 2 and 3). We ruled out alternative explanations, including pre-test of task equivalence[7] (Study 1A), creativity of the idea[8] (Study 4), task equivalence, effort, engagement, positive affect, brand liking, and willingness to pay (Study 5).

Theoretical and Practical Implications

For decades, brands have been trying to connect with consumers by engaging them through a variety of methods such as newsletter subscription, website and shop visits, and social media interactions (Leung et al., 2022; Wies et al., 2022). Indeed, consumer involvement enhances consumer loyalty, satisfaction, empowerment, connection, emotional bonding, trust, and commitment (Brodie et al., 2013) that lead to numerous marketing benefits including increased word of mouth (Kumar et al., 2010), brand attachment (Thomson, 2006), customer life-time value (Kumar et al., 2010), brand equity (Goldsmith, 2012; Leckie et al., 2016), and recovery from brand transgressions (Aaker et al., 2004). Our findings suggest that when consumer involvement affords the chance for consumers to be creative, self-brand connection is strengthened and these benefits might be amplified.

Our findings might also have broader implications for relationships when the target of connection is not necessarily a brand but another individual, small group, or organization. Practices that allow people the opportunity to generate and share creative ideas with each other might yield benefits far beyond the intended goal of simply generating ideas (Sutton & Hargadon, 1996)—including strengthening bonds, boosting commitment, and possibly reducing turnover (O'Reilly & Chatman, 1986). It is also notable that we replicated previous research showing that being creative feels like an act of self-disclosure (Goncalo & Katz, 2020) and we corroborated this effect in a very different context (e.g., brands and not people). This suggests that the relationship between creativity and self-disclosure is robust and replicable.

Limits on Generality and Avenues for Future Research

Although our studies demonstrate consistent effects across multiple methodological approaches and participant samples, certain limitations suggest promising directions for future work. First, we did not compare creative self-disclosure to direct, personal self-disclosure where individuals carefully curate what is shared (see Nguyen & Slepian, 2022). Since creative ideation is less carefully curated and thus potentially more revealing of the self, such a comparison could further illuminate the role creativity plays in increasing feelings of connection. Second, it is difficult to know how long the increased self-brand connection effect will last. Therefore, future research could explore the effect of increased self-brand connection over time (Kim, Lucas, & Goncalo, 2023) to pin down whether or how long this effect might last and continue to impact judgments and behaviors. For example, does creative ideation lead to enduring positive attitudes about brands and other targets (Escalas & Bettman, 2003), as well as feelings of attachment (Thomson, 2006) over time? Would these bonds that are built lead to more positive valuation of the brand (Norton et al., 2012)? Would voluntary (vs. forced) participation strengthen the effect? Future research can investigate interventions to prolong the effect, such as asking ideators to also vote for ideas.

Furthermore, cultural differences in the definition of what creativity is (Loewenstein & Mueller, 2016) could shape how much people view their creative output as self-disclosing and how eagerly they internalize a brand. It is possible that the self-disclosure effect and subsequent consequences might be stronger in cultures that more strongly view creative ideas as intertwined with the self as opposed to appealing to perceptions of feasibility and appeal to others (Loewenstein & Mueller, 2016). Additionally, we did not investigate the possibility that individuals could share their ideas with a target that provides negative feedback or rejects them (Goncalo, Katz, Vincent, et al., 2021). It is possible that such outright rejection, given that individuals might feel vulnerable because

of the perception of self-disclosure, might reverse the effect on social connection and lead instead to severed social ties.

Lastly, although we focused on a narrow set of commercial brands in this research, future research can try to use creative engagement as an intervention to help a broader set of brands including technology brands as well as non-commercial brands. For example, local police departments could solicit creative ideas to make use of an empty space near the police station. This may strengthen the local community members' feelings of connection with the "brand" (i.e., local police department), let alone providing an opportunity to receive creative ideas to utilize an empty space. By examining these and other boundary conditions, future research can help clarify both the power and the pitfalls of creative idea-sharing as a vehicle for building enduring relationships.

Authors' Note

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Supplemental Material

Supplemental material is available online with this article.

Notes

1. For the details about what the participants wrote in the feedback condition, please see Web Appendix C.
2. See Figure 1 for mediation analysis.
3. See Table 1 for correlation analysis.
4. There was no difference in creativity score between idea "share" versus "not share" condition ($p = .924$).
5. Please note that excluding participants based on the pre-registration did not change the interpretation of any of the results reported. If anything, the effects were stronger when we included all of the collected data points.
6. We added the following sentence at the beginning of the task instructions from Study 1A to make the treatment and control condition as similar as possible: "Please think back to the information you read about the brand Melody Candle." For specific details, please see our study materials on OSF.
7. Measures include the following: likability of the target brand, expected effort to be exerted on the task, helpfulness, enjoyability, and meaningfulness of task.
8. We tested whether the rated creativity of ideas correlated with self-brand connection and found no significant relationship ($r = -.055$, $p = .387$), ruling out the possibility that creativity per se drove self-brand connection (please see Web Appendix C for main effect). Water bottle choice was also not correlated with creativity ($r = .050$, $p = .434$).

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